

Spot–Vol Dynamics: SSR and Smile Transport

Moving the smile when spot moves, without recalibration

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Abstract

When the underlying moves, the implied-volatility smile moves with it, and a desk must know *how* — to risk-manage, to scenario, and to refresh a surface between calibrations. This note documents the Vol-Fitter’s spot–vol dynamics. The organizing quantity is the skew-stickiness ratio $SSR = (d\sigma_{\text{atm}}/d \ln F)/\text{skew}$, the fraction of the skew realized as an ATM-vol change per unit log-spot move. Three canonical regimes fix it: sticky-moneyness ($SSR = 0$, the smile rides with the forward), sticky-strike ($SSR = 1$, vol fixed at each strike), and sticky-local-vol ($SSR \approx 2$ for short-dated skews). We give the analytic transport that realizes any SSR in one line, derive its ATM response, and then the *exact* sticky-local-vol transport (a Hagan-style log-moneyness displacement) and the local-vol-grid relabeling that implements it by simply re-indexing the surface’s strike nodes. All of it is recalibration-free: a spot move refreshes the surface by arithmetic, not by re-solving. A worked example transports an equity smile under a -5% move in the three regimes.

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1 The question

A calibrated surface is a snapshot at one spot. The next tick moves spot, and the desk needs the new smile *now* — faster than a recalibration, and consistent with a chosen dynamics assumption. The assumptions differ in how much the ATM vol follows the skew as spot moves, and the summary statistic is the *skew-stickiness ratio*

$$\text{SSR} = \frac{d\sigma_{\text{atm}}/d \ln F}{s_0}, \quad s_0 = \left. \frac{\partial \sigma}{\partial k} \right|_{k=0} \quad (\text{the ATM skew}). \quad (1)$$

Heuristic

Read SSR as “how much of the skew is real”. The skew s_0 says that lower strikes have higher vol. When spot drops, does the ATM vol rise to where the old lower-strike vol was (SSR=1, sticky-strike), not move at all in moneyness terms (SSR=0, sticky-moneyness), or *overshoot* (SSR≈2, sticky-local-vol, the empirically common short-dated regime)? SSR interpolates these, and the transport below realizes any value of it.

2 The analytic transport

Let $h = \delta = \ln(F_{\text{new}}/F_{\text{old}})$ be the log-forward move and $\sigma_{\text{old}}(k)$ the pre-move smile in log-moneyness. The Vol-Fitter transports the smile to new-forward moneyness k by

$$\sigma_{\text{new}}(k) = \sigma_{\text{old}}(k + \delta) + (\text{SSR} - 1) s_0 \delta. \quad (2)$$

The first term is a *sticky-strike re-indexing* (a strike that was at moneyness $k + \delta$ before the move is at moneyness k after it); the second is a uniform *level adjustment* that dials in the desired ATM response while preserving the smile shape. The transport (2) is literally one line (matches production to 10^{-13}):

Listing 1: The SSR smile transport (2) for any regime (distilled from `dynamics/ssr.py`).

```
1 def shifted_smile(k, vol_curve, atm_skew, spot_return, ssr):
2     d = np.log1p(spot_return) # delta = log(
      F_new / F_old)
3     return vol_curve(k + d) + (ssr - 1.0)*atm_skew*d # sticky-strike
      reindex + level adj
```

Proposition 1 (ATM response). *Under (2), to first order in δ the ATM vol moves by $\Delta\sigma_{\text{atm}} = \text{SSR} \cdot s_0 \cdot \delta$, consistent with the SSR definition (1).*

Proof. At $k = 0$, $\sigma_{\text{new}}(0) = \sigma_{\text{old}}(\delta) + (\text{SSR} - 1)s_0\delta = \sigma_{\text{old}}(0) + s_0\delta + (\text{SSR} - 1)s_0\delta + O(\delta^2) = \sigma_{\text{old}}(0) + \text{SSR} s_0\delta + O(\delta^2)$. $\square$

So SSR = 0 leaves the smile a pure function of moneyness (sticky-moneyness: $\Delta\sigma_{\text{atm}} = 0$), SSR = 1 cancels the level term and freezes vol at each strike (sticky-strike), and SSR = 2 doubles the skew’s contribution. Figure 1 transports an equity smile (ATM skew $s_0 = -0.353$) under a −5% move in all three regimes; section 2 shows the linear ATM responses of slope SSR s_0 .

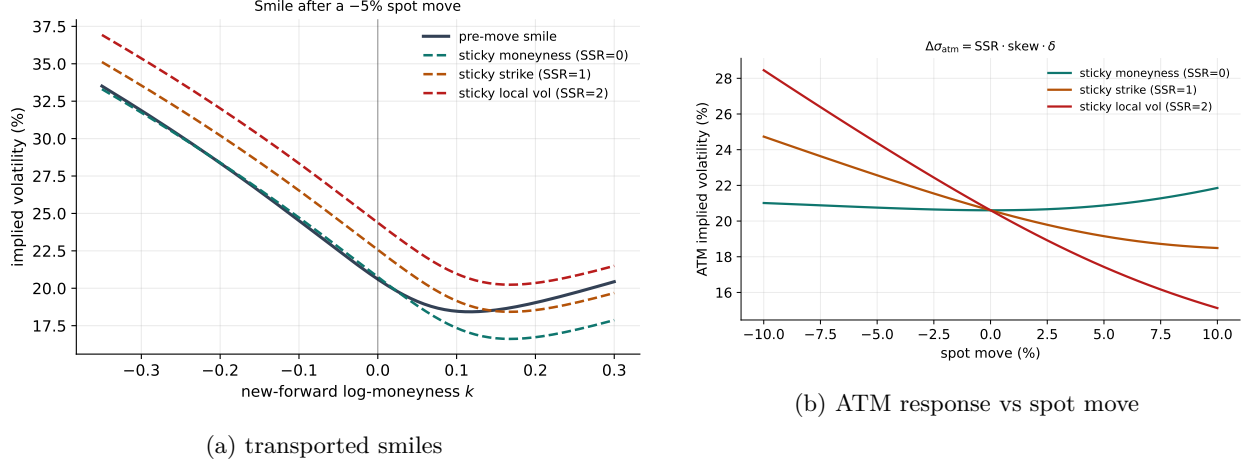


Figure 1: Transporting an equity smile under a -5% spot move in the three canonical regimes. The ATM response is linear with slope $\text{SSR} \cdot s_0$.

3 Exact sticky-local-vol

The shift (2) is a first-order, shape-preserving approximation. For the *sticky-local-vol* regime there is an *exact* transport, because holding the local-volatility function fixed in absolute strike determines the new implied surface completely. In total-variance form, the horizontal-SSR transport is

$$\tilde{w}_1^R(T, k) = w_0(T, k + R h_T), \quad (3)$$

and the exact sticky-local-vol transport replaces the linear displacement by the Hagan log-moneyness map

$$w_1^{\text{LV}}(T, k) = w_0(T, \ell_T(k, h)), \quad \ell_T(k, h) = \log(e^h(e^k + 1) - 1), \quad (4)$$

which is the exact relabeling of moneyness when the local-vol surface is held fixed in absolute strike and the forward moves by h . An optional ATM re-anchor $\sigma_{\text{atm}} \rightarrow \sigma_0 + R \kappa_T h_T$ makes the linear SSR response exact even for large moves.

3.1 The local-vol-grid relabeling

When the dynamics are driven by the extracted local-vol *grid* (Note 04), the transport is even simpler: it is a *relabeling of the grid's strike nodes*. A grid node at absolute strike $K_i^0(t)$ moves to

$$K_i^{1,R}(t) = K_i^0(t) e^{(1-R/2)h_t}, \quad \Longleftrightarrow \quad x_i^1 = x_i^0 - \frac{R}{2} h_t, \quad (5)$$

in forward-normalized moneyness x . For $R = 2$ (sticky-local-vol) the factor is $e^0 = 1$: the grid is held fixed in absolute strike and re-priced through the Dupire PDE, which is the *exact* dynamics — here SSR is an *output* of the reprice, not an input, and the value 2 is only its short-maturity limit. For $R = 0$ (sticky-moneyness) the grid scales with the forward; $R = 1$ (sticky-strike) sits halfway.

This is why the local-vol regime is labeled both `sticky_local_vol` (the analytic Hagan transport) and `sticky_local_vol_grid` (the exact PDE reprice).

Heuristic

The grid relabeling (5) is the cleanest statement of the whole note: a stickiness regime is just a rule for *how the local-vol grid's strikes follow the spot*. $1 - R/2$ is the fraction of the spot move the grid follows — none of it ($R = 2$, grid frozen in strike), all of it ($R = 0$, grid rides the forward), or half ($R = 1$). Everything else — the implied-vol shift (2), the ATM response, the Hagan map — is a consequence of that one rule.

4 What is original here

The SSR and the stickiness regimes are standard (Bergomi, Hagan); the value here is the *unified, recalibration-free* implementation. The single transport (2) realizes *any* SSR (named regime or custom number) by arithmetic on the existing curve; the exact sticky-local-vol path (4)–(5) ties the analytic shift, the Hagan relabeling, and the local-vol-grid reprice into one parameter R ; and because the local-vol regime can be either the analytic transport or the exact PDE reprice, the desk can trade speed for exactness on one slider. No spot move ever triggers a re-solve.

A Hyperparameter atlas

Table 1: Spot–vol–dynamics hyperparameters.

Knob	Default	Role
<code>ssr</code>	2.0	SSR value or named regime (<code>sticky_moneyness</code> / <code>sticky_strike</code> / <code>sticky_local_vol</code> / <code>sticky_local_vol_grid</code>).
R regime map	$\{0, 1, 2, 2\}$	SSR of the four named regimes.
ATM re-anchor	off	Optional exact linear SSR for large moves ($\sigma_0 + R\kappa_T h_T$).

Performance. The analytic transport (2) and the grid relabeling (5) are $O(\text{grid})$ arithmetic — no optimization, no PDE — so a spot move refreshes the whole surface essentially for free. Only the exact sticky-local-vol-grid reprice costs a Dupire PDE solve, and is chosen explicitly when exactness is wanted over speed. A spot move bumps the per-ticker spot version, so only the moved name's derived grid is re-transported.

References

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- [3] J. Gatheral. *The Volatility Surface*. Wiley, 2006.